TIMURID MATRIARCHS AND THEIR COLOSSAL DREAMS

When the Mughal court moved to the new capital city at Agra on the last day of 1560, it had a new wakil-e-saltanat.* When the imperial camp reached the city, colourful tents and fluttering pavilions were set up inside the fortress of Badalgarh and Munim Khan was assigned Bairam Khan's old quarters. To celebrate this remarkable reversal in his fortunes, the new khankhanan held a grand banquet to which he invited Akbar. To have the Padshah himself grace one's home was considered a unique honour and an exceptional privilege and Munim Khan served Akbar himself, and offered him magnificent gifts. With his ethnic Turki background, Munim Khan may have included dishes at his banquet that reflected his lustrous heritage. Grains were an important part of Turki diet and kashk, a porridge made of crushed wheat and meat, may have been served in addition to more extravagant dishes such as murg mussalam, an elaborate item made by removing the bones of a whole chicken, marinating it in yoghurt and spices, stuffing it with rice, nuts, minced meat, and boiled eggs, and then baking it in clarified butter and yet more spices.

Akbar was making such visible signs of favour to Munim Khan because not everyone was satisfied with this choice and there were other contenders jostling for key positions. A cautious, careful man, whose nature appeared to be reflected in a perennially worried expression and a scraggly beard, there were others who were more ruthless than Munim Khan. Principal among them was Akbar's foster father, Ataka Khan, who wrote a long, complaining letter to the Padshah saying that though he had been awarded Bairam Khan's 'banner, drums and tuman tugh…a fur garment, a robe of victory, and insignia of pomp', he had hoped to gain Bairam Khan's title of khankhanan too. But Akbar was unmoved and propitiated him with the title azam khan.

Akbar at eighteen had grown into a young man of impressive physical strength. 'He was of medium stature but inclining to be tall,' wrote his son, Jahangir, in his memoir. 'His complexion was wheaten or nut coloured, rather dark than fair, his eyes and eyebrows dark black and the latter running across into each other; with a handsome person, he had a lion's